

On average, the CPU throttles only 7% while performing intensive tasks, which highlights the tight synergy between the hardware and software.

For gamers, frame rates remain stable even in more demanding titles like BGMI and Genshin Impact, and the 120Hz refresh rate with 1000Hz touch sampling in gaming mode gives you a responsive experience.

What's particularly interesting is that in a time where most brands go bananas highlighting the AI smartness of their phones, Nothing stands out by not giving into all of those rarely used features like AI summary, proofreading, editing, etc. Instead, you get the Essential Key. It takes you to the Essential Space, which is essentially an AI-powered hub for notes, ideas and inspiration. Look at it like an extension of your to-do list: single-press to save something you want to remember, long-press to record a voice note and double-tap to access the Essential Space. While many of its most interesting features like on-device voice-to-text transcription are still in early access, the concept is promising and could genuinely change how you interact with your phone.

This is my first encounter with the Nothing OS and I have to say, there's nothing like it on the shelves. It is refreshingly different from other Android skins without being weird or confusing.

Nothing OS 3.1 is the company's most refined software experience to date. It's clean, minimal, and distinctly Nothing with those dot-matrix animations, custom icons and 51 distinct sounds that give a unique character to the Phone 3a. There's no bloatware, and the customization options let you make it as simple or feature-rich as you want.

The Smart Drawer that automatically organizes your apps by category is genuinely useful, not just eye candy. If you're tired of cluttered, ad-filled interfaces, the Nothing OS is a breath of fresh air. The company has improved its update cadence over time, and the Phone 3a also gets 3 years of Android updates and 6 years of security patches, which is solid for this price range.

CAMERAS

The camera system represents perhaps the biggest upgrade in the 3a series. Both models feature triple rear cameras but with some key differences. The standard Phone 3a includes a 50MP main camera with OIS and EIS, a 50MP telephoto with 2x optical zoom and up to 4x lossless in-sensor zoom, an 8MP ultra-wide with a 120° field of view and a 32MP front camera. The Pro model steps things up with a 50MP main camera with a larger sensor, a 50MP periscope telephoto with 3x optical zoom, OIS, and up to 6x lossless zoom, the same 8MP ultra-wide and an upgraded 50MP front camera capable of 4K video recording.

Nothing's image processing system that it calls TrueLens Engine 3.0, which combines AI tone mapping and scene detection to provide more natural and balanced photos. The Ultra XDR feature takes 8 RAW images at different exposures and combines them for excellent dynamic range. The addition of presets gives you a lot of ground to experiment with different colour tones and effects like soft focus and lenticular. Video capabilities are solid too, with 4K/30fps recording, combined OIS (only on the main camera) and EIS stabilization.

The camera on the 3a captures true-to-life colours in daylight, however, in some images, there is a significant colour difference between the output from all three lenses. Low light performance is greatly improved, but Nothing will need more computational photography wizardry to make it consistent on all days. These little issues can of course be fixed via an OTA update and I hope the camera improves in the coming months.

BATTERY LIFE & CHARGING

The Phone 3a has a 5000mAh battery, the same as the 2a and 2a Plus. Nothing claims up to 2 days of use on a full charge and our testing largely backs this up in casual use. But if you are a heavy user, you can expect a day's worth of heavy use and still end up with around 10% battery.

The Nothing OS, along with the Snapdragon 7s Gen 3, is efficiently optimised to use less power for small tasks, which

in turn gives you better battery life. In mixed-use, the Phone 3a was able to power through tasks involving browsing, photo-video editing, document editing, watching videos, etc, for 12 hours in our battery drain test. Plus, the 50W charging isn't the absolute fastest, but it'll still get you from 1% to 100% in about 56 minutes, and 1 to 50% in 20 minutes. But sadly, the charging adapter is sold separately. Nothing claims the phone can maintain over 90% maximum capacity after 1,200 charging cycles, roughly 3 years and 4 months of daily charging.

VERDICT

What makes the Phone 3a cool isn't just any single feature but the cohesive vision behind it. It's genuinely interesting, capable, and fun to use. From hardware to software, Nothing has created a device with a clear identity and purpose in a market where many phones feel interchangeable. The Phone 3a is for those who want a phone that feels different without sacrificing the essentials. In its price range, the Phone 3a series faces stiff competition but fewer competitors offer anything as distinctive as the transparent back and Glyph Interface, and Nothing OS, which provides one of the cleanest Android experiences. Battery life is strong across the board, and the display quality is one of the best in this segment. Some competitors offer slightly better raw performance. For most people, the difference won't be noticeable in day-to-day use, but if you're the type who needs the absolute maximum processing power, there might be better options out there specifically for gaming like the Poco F6 or the X7 Pro.

—Siddharth Chauhan

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 7s Gen 3 | GPU: Adreno 710 | RAM: 8GB/12GB | Storage 128GB/256GB | OS: Android 15, Nothing OS 3.1 | Display: 6.77" AMOLED, HDR10+, 2392 x 1080 pixels | Refresh Rate: 120 Hz | IP Rating: IP64 | Cameras: 50 MP + 50 MP + 8 MP | Selfie Camera: 32 MP | Video: Up to 4K at 30 fps | Battery Capacity: 5,000 mAh Si/C | Charging: 50 W (wired)

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